WAR AGAINST TB

In 2018, the Centre set 2025 as the target for the elimination of TB in India. Though that may be more optimistic than realistic, here are a few milestones

WHAT HAS BEEN DONE

- Lakshadweep and Budgam district in J&K declared TB-free in 2021
- Nine districts from various states achieve 60 per cent reduction in cases between 2015 and 2021
- 75,000 people and organisations under Ni-kshay Mitra have adopted 1 mn patients, helping them not just with funds, but also community support
- Increased access to faster, more accurate TB diagnosis. The number of CBNAAT/TrueNAT facilities in the country has gone up to 5,090 from a mere 40 in 2014
- In 2021, as many as 34 states/UTs conducted door-to-door campaigns, screening over 223 mn people. This resulted in a 19 per cent rise in the number of new cases diagnosed that year
- Engagement with the private sector has yielded results—compared to 106,000 cases in 2014, 733,000 were reported in 2022
- Two critical drugs for DR-TB—bedaquiline and delamanid—are provided free of cost by the government at state-run centres and a few private hospitals
- New regimens are being studied, with the ICMR testing a drug that will bring down treatment duration from two years to six months
- Around 7.1 mn patients have got financial assistance worth Rs 2,100 crore since 2018



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WHAT REMAINS TO BE DONE

- The amount under Ni-kshay Poshan to support nutrition needs of TB patients must be increased to Rs 2,500 from Rs 500
- Bedaquiline and delamanid will go off patent this year. Generic versions of these must be produced and made available to reduce costs and duration for DR-TB treatment
- Psychological counselling must be provided to TB patients and their caregivers
- Policies must be tailored to ensure consequences for healthcare providers who fail to order a DR-TB test or prescribe incorrect dose/duration of vital antibiotics
- Stigma must be tackled through sustained campaigns
- TB survivors can be made part of communication and support strategies

nosed. Reporting from private sector hospitals too increased significantly—from 106,000 cases in 2014 to 733,000 cases in 2022. In fact, the largest number of TB cases are diagnosed and treated in the private sector. Various state governments have now started building partnerships to improve diagnosis.

Haryana is showing the way. Gurugram's Medanta hospital is working with the state in the mission to end TB by 2025. Medanta chairman Dr Naresh Trehan cites a crucial intervention his hospital has made. "We realised analog x-rays are not reliable for diagnosis and rural areas in the state needed digital x-ray technologies. So, we created mobile vans equipped with digital x-rays and installed molecular technologies as well for quick diagnosis of DR-TB," he says. The hospital also undertook door-to-door active case detection and found it resulted in detection rates three times higher than waiting for patients to come in for a test. "We're also engaging with people to improve awareness of TB symptoms, and finding out more about the outcomes of our TB treatments," adds Dr Trehan. Such partnerships, he feels, will be key to helping rid India of this scourge.

THE TREATMENT REVOLUTION

In an encouraging observation, the India TB Report noted that of the people diagnosed with TB in 2021, almost 95.5 per